Claw and Order

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by ManInTheBlueSuit

Summary

Detective Grayskull has dedicated her life to fighting crime and injustice. Catra D'riluth has dedicated her efforts to helping her clients avoid punishment and retribution. Their conflict can only end one way.

OR

Cop Adora meets Lawyer Catra because who doesn't want to see them wearing suits and being at odds?

Chapter 1: The Chase

Adora waited in tense silence as Judge Triton flicked through the thick wedge of paperwork she'd presented. It had been ten minutes already. Ten minutes, as he picked through the testimony, going over the implications of what they had provided. The smug aura to her left kept getting smugger the longer they waited. Eventually, Triton flipped the brown wallet closed and removed his spectacles to look up at the pair.

"I see insufficient reasoning here to establish protection for a confidential informant," He scowled. "I'm sorry, Detective Grayskull, you'll have to do better next time." A scarred hand held out the file for her to take.

"Your Honour!" Adora couldn't believe what she was hearing. "We've got testimony on insider trading, backalley deals, corruption at *all* levels - more than enough to gain a subpoena and force Prime to share their financial records!"

"Your Honour," Adora hated how polished and fucking *reasonable* that tone was. Because that wasn't how she spoke at all. "Financial records would implicate our clients and unduly infringe upon our confidentiality with them. And all this on what?" She smirked. "A single, unnamed source? We have no reason to believe that this so-called 'evidence' was not concocted by a member of Detective Adora's department."

"There's a clear line of evidence, it's obvious to anyone with even half a brain!" Adora snatched the file and began flipping through the papers for herself. "Prime is funnelling funds to buy their way through courts, twist the laws to suit themselves, disguising their acts through various charitable foundations to launder the money!"

"And, if you have any *real* evidence, we would be happy to open our books," Came the calm retort. "Once you have a subpoena, based upon the sworn testimony of at least one *genuine* source,

we'll begin a thorough analysis of any associated accounts to ensure we don't compromise our clients privacy, and then proceed to personally deliver all relevant records straight to your desk."

"And how long would that take?!" Adora snapped. "Ten months? Twenty?"

"Justice can't be rushed."

"Not when it can be crippled to the point of being useless." Adora snapped.

"Detective!" Triton warned. "You're out of line."

"And?" Adora said irritability. "It's not as if we punish criminals when we've got witness statements, I'm sure poor manners aren't going to get me thrown in jail." She stormed out, folder clutched tightly in her fist.

"Adora!" Glimmer and Bow were waiting outside for her. "How did it go? Did we get the warrant?"

"How are we supposed to establish a credible informant if none of their evidence is allowed to make it to trial in the first place?!" Adora snapped, thumping the wall.

"We can appeal," Glimmer promised. "Another judge will see it clearer."
"I wouldn't count on it," The most unwelcome voice possible sounded from behind them. "Hey Adora," The detective turned, fuming at the smug tone. "And look, you brought the dork and the disappearing act." Catra smirked, briefcase tapping gently against her thigh.

"*Catra.*" Adora took a step closer, instantly pulled back by her friends.

"No, please," Catra taunted. "Let her come - I'll be able to close out another case without even having to leave the building. Who knows? Maybe I'll set a record."

"The case was dismissed," Glimmer said icily. "Unless Prime pays you extra to gloat, I suggest you leave."

"Aw, Sparkles," She pouted. "You're no *fun.*" Catra glanced to Bow. "What about you?" She said cockily. "I hear you know how to make a mean cocktail."

"I know how to make a lot of things," Bow said stiffly. "You just know how to make them disappear."

"Me?" Catra acted indignant as she splayed fingers across her shirt that cost more than their monthly salaries. They didn't have to guess that; she'd openly shared as much. "I didn't do anything, really! If your girlfriend hadn't put together such a sloppy argument," Bow managed to grab Glimmer before she could lunge. "Well," Catra smirked once more. "See you at the next one - try and make it a bit more challenging next time." She strutted away, heels clicking in the hallway.

"Do you think Prime would make Catra disappear if we said that she was the inside source?" Glimmer muttered darkly.

"Glimmer!" Bow gasped. "We can't do that!"

"No, we *shouldn't* do that." Glimmer corrected. "Adora?"

"It would certainly get at least one of their lawyers off the street." She growled. "Come on, we should get back to the station." It wasn't as if they had any reason to hang around the courts at this point.

They returned to the station with heavy hearts and angry fists. The worst part was how nobody was disappointed in them. It had become routine for their efforts in fighting Prime to go unrewarded - they were the most powerful legal firm in existence, and had more resources than a kingdom (a *rich* kingdom). No matter what was thrown at them, there wasn't enough evidence to convict even a single member of so much as a parking ticket.

"Okay," Glimmer mused as they gathered around Adora's desk. "Bow cooks up some truth serum, we sprinkle it into the air conditioning at the court, launch some bogus lawsuit to get them inside, then *bam!*" She slammed herself onto the desk as Adora slumped in the chair. "We get them to spill the beans."

"Except that I have to arrest you for administering a controlled substance without a license, tampering with witnesses, and generally being a pest." Adora muttered against her fist.

"And there's no such thing as truth serum," Bow pointed out. "Besides mixing some sodium pentathol and amobarbital in a base solution, I can't think of how that would even work."

"Well?" Glimmer demanded. "Whip away!" A few startled faces glanced their way as her words were taken out of context.

"I'm a lab technician," Bow reminded her. "Not a miracle worker."

"Lies!" Glimmer insisted. "Lies and slander." She glanced at her friend. "Adora, back me up." Adora swayed in her chair, not paying any attention. "Don't worry," Glimmer smiled cheerfully back at Bow. "I'll take your case pro bono."

"The case of you insisting that I'm skilled enough to break the law and get away with it?" Bow frowned. "Which side are you going to argue?"

"Yes!" Glimmer beamed happily.

"Fuck it," Adora swore, grabbing her weapon and badge, and throwing her coat on over the top. "I'm going to walk the beat. Maybe I'll get lucky and catch some gang activity."

"What activity?" Bow rolled his eyes. "Huntara has the gangs under control."

"Then maybe I'll find a cat stuck up a tree!" She snapped, stomping out of the precinct.

Glimmer and Bow watched her slam into a squad car as it pulled towards the parking space she was walking through. They couldn't hear the exact discussion from the window, but the car slowly reversed out, flicking lights on to alert the rest of the traffic to a crossing pedestrian. "We need to get her laid." Glimmer decided bracingly.

"How?" Bow shrugged. "Last time we tried setting her up with someone, it ended in handcuffs."

"As long as they had a safe word." Glimmer smirked.

"She arrested him for tax evasion." Bow glared.

"Before or after?"

"A-hem!" Glimmer shot upright with a startled expression. "Shouldn't you be preparing cases or something?" The captain of the squad glared down at her.

"But Mo, er, Captain Angella," Glimmer switched tracks halfway through. "I spent weeks preparing that dossier for Judge Triton, and he threw it back in our faces."

Angella's expression softened slightly. "Then I suppose we shall have to try again," She said supportingly, even if the fight had left her heart long ago. "Where did Adora go?"

"She went to walk a beat?" Bow asked nervously. Technically, detectives didn't walk beats, but there was no rule forbidding it.

"Oh dear," Angella sighed. "That bad?" Adora only walked a beat when the situation was truly terrible.

"Catra." Glimmer winced. Angella sighed and pinched the bridge of her nose.

"Bow?" She said without opening her eyes. "Can you make anything to give her to stop this from happening again?"

"What is it with you two and thinking that I can just whip up anything that springs to mind?" Angella dragged her hand down her face to glare as Glimmer stared in confusion.

"Because you can?"

Bow frowned. For a compliment, it sounded dreadfully insulting. "I think anything strong enough to calm her down might stop her heart."

"I don't think that's strong enough." Glimmer mused. "What?" She noticed the glare her mother/captain was sending. "Do you think Adora would slow down just because her heart stops?"

With the level of rage shuddering in her body, the answer was a strong negative.

Adora was faintly trembling as she stomped down the sidewalk. It was possible for a cop to get into trouble anywhere they weren't wanted, and cops were rarely wanted anywhere. Stalking through the bad parts of town should at least have triggered her some foul looks. Except that she had a twisted sense of protection unwillingly forced against her by the biggest thug on the block.

"Sup, Blondie?" Huntara called cheerfully from her perch on a fire escape. Adora resisted the urge to respond and choked the urge to flip her off. Huntara had an unofficial hands-off policy protecting her and her gang. Even Adora could see that having a firm hand on the criminal underworld was restricting the amount of violent crime, allowing a limited measure of social stability and rebuilding. "I heard that your case fell apart before even reaching the bench?"

That forced Adora to stop. "Who from?" She called up.

"Little bird told me." Huntara smiled like the cat that ate the canary once it was done singing. "Is it true?"

"No comment." Adora snapped, continuing on amidst the callous laughter. Huntara continued mocking her as she walked away. It hurt, but there was no way she could react and indicate that Huntara had been the one to give her the tip on Prime's illegal activities. A background being their fixer had given her extensive insight into how they operated. She was fine going her own way and staying out of theirs until they started infringing on her turf. After that, it was fair game. But there was no way to go up against an expensive legal firm and win. Luckily, she and the cops had a mutual enmity to go on, and she was willing to share a few unsavoury details of their operations in exchange for going unnamed on the forms.

It also meant that she couldn't drag Huntara in on some stupid charges that would force her to fess up more than what she knew - not without blaring that Huntara was involved. And, as much as she hated the beautiful thug, she didn't want her dead. One sign to Prime that she was talking to Huntara, and both their heads would be on a silver platter in front of Hordak before dinner. Legally speaking, if they were lucky. Literally, if not.

Movement in the distance caught her eye, and Adora froze. She knew that hairstyle better than her own.

Catra. Walking around the Wastes like she was at home.

Adora slipped behind a newsstand, watching in a shop window as Catra turned to glance back along the street. What was someone who could afford to buy entire apartments outright doing entering a ramshackle building that was too dilapidated to condemn?

"If you're not buying, then get lost." The newsagent swore at her. Adora was tempted to flash her badge, but it wouldn't have done anything. Instead, she gave a surly glare as she slipped inside the same building Catra had entered.

Inside was more underwhelming than the outside. Somehow, there was a functional elevator, the numbers gently ticking upward. Adora muttered a few of the coarser swears she'd picked

up over the years and sprinted for the stairs. Lifts this old would creak up the shaft slower than Razz could clamber the stairs, but trust a rich lawyer to not know that. She was soon able to overtake the lift, poking her head outside the stairwell to check if it was stopping on each floor. It finally stopped on the eighth, her body soaked with sweat and her heartbeat pounding in her ears powerfully enough that she nearly missed the slow clicking of heels away from her down the hallway. They turned a corner, and she broke cover, silently chasing after them in a low crouch until she reached the corner.

A knock sounded, and she waited breathlessly as a door creaked open.

"You're late." A rough voice growled.

"I had to shake a tail," Catra snapped. "Do you want to do business or not?" She strode forward without waiting for a response, the door creaking shut behind her. Adora had enough time to glance around the corner and nail the closing strip of light.

Whatever rent was being paid clearly didn't go towards noise insulation, because she was able to hear every word inside the room by pressing her ear to the frame.

"... can't keep dealing with you at these prices." The resident was saying.

"Fuck off, Grizzlor," Catra retorted. "You'd still be making toilet wine on death row if I hadn't squared your case."

Grizzlor. Adora remembered that one. Convicted of murder before Catra proved that he'd merely stolen the skiff with a dead body inside, not committed the stabbing himself. He'd gotten out with time served, and Catra had moved up the ranks of Prime.

"And I've paid you back for that," Grizzlor insisted.

"Hardly," The lawyer snapped. "You can't afford my retainer, let alone my fees. You help me out, and I don't garnish your wages -

I even make sure you've got enough to get by."

"Maybe I want a little more." Grizzlor snarled.

"Get your hands *off of me!*" Catra yelled.

That was enough eavesdropping. Rearing back, Adora planted her boot near the frame and kicked her way inside.

In the split second that the door was still thudding open, Adora captured a snapshot of the entire room: a ratty couch with tattered cushions, the burly man with the rugged beard and wild mane, and Catra whirling to process the sudden change in circumstances and head for the exit.

Catra tried to run past her, and Adora acted on instinct, flinging both arms into a tackle and launching them backwards onto the coffee table.

The cheap wood splintered beneath them, coating them both in sour coffee and exploding packets of white powder.

Grizzlor looked down at them with a calculating expression. "Thank goodness that you're here," He grinned. "This lawyer was threatening to frame me for possession of moon powder!"

Moon powder? Adora looked down at her clothes in horror. "You're under arrest," She growled, already reaching for her radio.

Chapter 2: The Invasion

It was everything needed for a good conviction: a detective on the scene, a culprit caught in the act, and a witness willing to testify.

"We're cutting her loose." Angella announced the next morning as Adora stood before her in workout gear and a department windbreaker.

"Captain, I *swear*, this was a good arrest," Adora promised. "We've caught worse people on less."

"When?!" Angella thumped a fist on her desk. "Because the only situation I've seen worse than this is the time that rookie booked his own weapon into evidence on a murder case! If you'd listened at the door for even a minute, you'd have heard that she was pressing a C.I. for information!"

"Like hell she was!" Adora yelled. "She went there to buy bags of moon powder!"

"You don't know that!" The captain roared, pounding both fists in the table as she rose to her feet. "All you have is one private citizen entering a private residence where drugs *happened* to be present! And because of *your* assault, they now have enough reasonable doubt that this case is *never* going to come close to trial!"

Adora swallowed nervously. Angella didn't get angry often. When she did, it was because someone had royally screwed up. "You're taking the rest of the week to try and get your head screwed on straight," Angella ordered, sitting back down. "Set one foot back in the precinct before then, and it'll be a disciplinary."

"Captain,"

"Bottom line, detective," Angella glared. "You might be testing clean, but that stuff you rolled around in can stick in your system

for the next few days if you got exposed." Moon powder was so potent that Adora had spent the entire night on a detox regime while her clothes were burned. It was humiliating, only made worse by the knowledge that Catra's private medical insurance had netted her a better room. "The best thing that you can do is go home, hunker down, and let it pass. We'll clear up the mess."

"Mess?" Adora yelled.

"Yes, *mess*!" Angella lost her temper. "You lost an injunction to a lawyer at the Prime firm and just hours later happen to track her down to a shady apartment where a controlled substance is found?! What sort of events do you think people are going to believe - that you stumbled across someone like *her* in a place like *that* or that you orchestrated the entire situation to get revenge?" The accusation knocked the fight from the detective.

"I thought you knew me better than that." Adora whimpered.

Angella sighed, stepping around the table to lay a hand on her shoulder. "I do," She promised. "But the optics are terrible on this one. Letting Catra go wasn't a choice, it was because I had Prime's COO on the phone with me before you even brought Catra into holding. Even Glimmer admitted that it would be an uphill struggle. The best we can do today is turn her loose, explain that we don't have enough to hold her on, and hope the situation dies down. Now," She removed her hand and gestured to the door. "Update Sergeant Juliet on your cases and get some rest. This won't even come out of your leave."

"Yes, captain," Adora grumbled. "Whatever you say."

Getting home in the afternoon after thirty hours of uninterrupted consciousness was about as fun as Juliet's expression when Adora explained the situation. Part of the emergency detox protocol for moon powder was ensuring that the patient didn't lapse into unconsciousness in case it was an overdose, so Adora was low on sleep, patience, and restraint when she finally came within

viewing distance of the door to her apartment and the unwelcome guest sitting opposite it.

"Hey Adora," Catra smirked brokenly. "How's it hanging?"

"*Catra,*" Adora glared. "How do you know where I live?"

"Are you kidding?" She inverted the bottle until a trickle ran down her chin. Breathing heavily, she lowered it down again, substantially lighter than before. "Prime has files on everyone that crosses our path. I read yours."

"You've got two minutes to get out of here before I have you trespassed." She snapped, striding down the hallway towards her home. Catra wordlessly held up a folded letter as Adora stepped by. "What's that?" She deliberately didn't take the paper as Catra let it fall to the floor.

"Termination papers," Catra mumbled. "I got *fired*."

Adora paused with her keys already in the lock. "What's the catch?" Because there was no other reason Catra would have shown up outside her apartment if there wasn't an extra twist coming.

"There's a non-compete clause," Catra grumbled. "I sign on the line, and I'll get enough money to retire twice over. Maybe move somewhere nice. But I can't ever work in anything that would potentially draw away from Prime's business interests." Adora sighed, leaning her forehead against the heavy wood of her door. She knew she was going to regret this.

Turning around, she stared at the sad bundle on the floor. "Why were you shopping for moon powder?" She asked. It was the one thing she couldn't understand - Catra was rich enough to have it delivered, if that was her vice. She didn't need to go to the Crimson Waste to get some.

"... It wasn't for me." Catra confessed.

"What? Hordak sends his top brass on drug runs for him?" The sickly figure at the top of the Prime firm had a gaunt appearance that could easily be the result of several addictions. Adora's tone was sarcastic but her desire to know was genuine.

"I was going to plant them on a client," Adora's world tilted beneath her feet. "He got off," Catra paused to cackle in disgust. "Cops picked him up from some internet traffic going through his computer. *Fucked up* stuff. We hired expert after expert to say that the routing software he was using could mimic data going to other devices as appearing on his system without his knowledge. I heard Octavia *brag* that she got a *bonus* for clearing that case." Upending the bottle, she drained the last of the contents. "Moon powder is one thing that we can't beat," She admitted. "I plant some in his possession, slip a little into his drink, and he's rotting in prison before we can even get our soldiers in order."

"That's so many layers of illegal that I wouldn't even know how to charge it," Adora glared. "Why didn't you just go to the police?"

"Confidentiality," Catra shrugged. "Soon as I break that, not only is my career over but my credibility is gone. Anything I say is instantly useless." She tried to drink from the bottle again, but might as well have not bothered. Setting the container down, she didn't bother righting it as it tumbled and rolled into her leg.

"Why are you here, Catra?" Adora asked.

"Where else could I go?" Catra laughed callously.

"Get a hotel." Adora shrugged. Catra said nothing. Very loudly. "*What?*"

"I don't know what to do with myself," Catra admitted. "Hotel for tonight. Then what tomorrow? Sign the paperwork, ride off into the sunset?" She grabbed the bottle, tilting it against her leg. "I got this for winning the Grizzlor case," She revealed. "Kept it in my drawer at work, saving it for a special occasion. Never thought it'd be this one."

'Don't do it! You're a detective, you *know* this is a trap, do not fall for'

"You can come inside." Adora mentally screamed at herself, wrapping an arm around Catra's back and steadying her against the wall as she unlocked the door.

"Wow," Catra slurred as she looked across the tiny apartment. "This is where you live?"

"We can't all live in fancy penthouse suites." Adora growled, already regretting her decision.

"No, I like it," Catra clarified. "It's nice." Nice? A kitchenette by the front door, a couch not ten feet away on the back wall under what couldn't be called a window because it faced an alleyway slimmer than a dumpster? "It's a home, you know? Not like my place."

Adora didn't know how to respond to that as Catra forcibly straightened up, restraining her wobble as she walked to the sofa. But then she had nowhere else to go, and collapsed in place, shifting into place as her world crumbled all over again.

"Adora?" Catra looked small for the first time that Adora could remember, huddled over on the ratty couch. "Can I tell you something?"

"Do I need a lawyer present?" Adora sarcastically retorted. A tiny smile flickered across Catra's face, and she squashed down the spark of pride it gave her.

"Come sit with me?" Catra shuffled to one end of the couch.

Adora sighed, carefully removing the gun from her holster, the clip from her gun, and leaving the entire weapon on the counter. "It's not that I don't trust you," She watched the heterochromatic eyes track the movement. "It's just that I don't trust you." Another flicker of a smile. Another spark of warmth in her chest.

Adora crossed the room and sat beside her worst enemy. "What did you want to tell me?"

"I just," She shivered, looking around. "Is your bedroom through there?" She nodded to the door.

"You're not getting in my bedroom," Adora warned. "There's blankets in the basket under the table, you can pile a couple of cushions and sleep out here."

Catra nodded, slowly looking down at her knees again. "How do you do it?" She asked.

"Do what?" Adora probed.

"How did you decide what was right and just… *do* it?" Catra mumbled. "Nobody ever thought I'd get anywhere, so I had to prove them wrong. I had to get the best grades, the best work, the best cases. It had to *mean* something. But it got taken away and I've got nothing. How is it that you keep *losing*, mostly to me, and still pick yourself up and do it again and again?"

Adora was quiet. Prime might have had a file on her, but she'd checked the files on Catra. "Because I have to," Catra blinked and glanced sideways at her. "It has to be on my shoulders because they're strong enough to carry it all. I *made* them strong enough by having people rely on me, and now I can rely on *them*. But I still need to keep them safe. So, every morning, I get up, get ready for the day, and get on with it."

"Sounds lonely." Catra said wistfully.

"I've got friends," Adora defended herself. "And people I work with who'd take a bullet for me."

"You know what I see when I look around my place?" Catra asked, casting her gaze across the apartment. "I don't see one picture, one person, one trace of any of that. That place looks like a showroom - I didn't have <u>anyone</u> looking out for me."

"I look out for you," Adora promised. "And you look out for me. Mainly to piss each other off, but it's better than nothing." Catra had come to her door, hadn't she? Maybe there was a connection between them. "What was the thing you wanted to tell me?" It was how Catra had lured her across to the sofa in the first place.

Gripping her arms tight, Catra straightened up and took a deep breath through her nose. "I'm drunk." She said flatly.

"... I know." Adora replied.

"No, I mean, I'm drunk, and I *know* I'm drunk," Catra repeated, snapping around to glare at Adora in a way that seemed beyond anger. "And that's good, because I'd never be able to do this sober."

"Do whm?" Adora was cut off by Catra darting in and pressing their lips together. She breathed in, tasting the berries and wine on her lips, on her tongue. A hand fastened on either shoulder, a leg swung over hers, and Catra was suddenly in her lap, hands reaching up to cup her face.

"Catra!" Adora grabbed her arms and forced her back.

"That's assault, *Detective*." Catra growled, snapping her arms free and pushing Adora's aside.

"You're drunk!" She snapped, ignoring how soft Catra felt, how sturdy her sinewy muscles were beneath the surface. "You can't consent to… *this*!"

Catra's eyes fastened onto that moment of uncertainty, and she moved in for the kill. "And you're not," She growled, leaning in. "And you *can*." She clutched Adora's face, fastening tight and feasting on her treasure.

"Fuck," She mumbled. "I've wanted to do this for so long."

"What?" Adora's brain was shutting down all unnecessary thoughts besides trying to find a way out of this nightmare and

trying to etch every second of it into her soul.

"First year you made detective, and I was in the defence," She mumbled, peppering impacts around Adora's jaw. "You put together such a case that I thought I was going to lose. I couldn't *stand* that you'd ruined all my hard work. You had it all laid out, the weapon, the evidence, the testimony. If the DNA hadn't been thrown out and ruined your entire argument, that bastard would have been locked away the rest of his life."

"It was a computer glitch," Adora growled. "The sample should have been purged but someone put the wrong date in when he was first arrested. Swapped the last two digits by mistake and let it stay in the system."

"Exactly!" Catra snapped, drawing back to stare down at her in fury. "How fucking *dare* you make me rely on *luck*? I should have beaten you because I was *better*. I couldn't get your face out of my head. You kept beating me, forcing me to *settle*." She grabbed Adora's hair, dragging it back to expose her throat so that she could swoop in and fasten her fangs on the pounding pulse. "*Apologise.*" She ordered, biting and sucking at the insatiable desire for more of this taste.

"Fuck you!" Adora gasped, fingers sinking into the taut muscles on Catra's upper thighs.

It was like a spell had broken. Catra stopped, leaning back with a shaky breath, and running one hand through her hair. "I was right," She said with forced nonchalance. "I *am* drunk." She glanced down at where Adora was still gripping her thighs. Adora looked down too, releasing her fingers but not removing them. "Well," Those sinful lips quirked in a smile as she removed the hairband keeping the ponytail in place. "I suppose one more wouldn't hurt." Catra felt the fingers twitch on her thighs as she curled in, carefully framing Adora's face and pressing her lips into place.

Time faded away as they moved together, Catra deliberately stretching the definition of a single kiss by never letting their lips part, even as they sucked in each breath. Fingers splayed across her back, touching on that sensitive spot at the base of her spine that drove her wild. She gasped, mouths breaking apart, as she wrapped both arms around Adora's shoulders, wishing that she could climb them like a tree. Ducking her face to the sturdy crook of Adora's neck, she breathed deeply and came back to her senses.

One kiss. She'd promised herself one kiss. But Adora had grabbed her and she couldn't let her win. Adora, who still had her fists clenched around the fabric of Catra's top. Adora, who was audibly gulping the air down beneath her. Adora, whose heartbeat was pounding so loudly that Catra was using it as a metronome to calm herself.

She eyed the mark she'd left along Adora's neck. Some make-up would swiftly conceal those. She hoped it rained so that they couldn't be hidden.

Clearing her throat, she clumsily reapplied her mask. "Thank you," The mask instantly slipped. "That was nice."

"Yeah?" Adora nodded dumbly.

"Yeah," Catra smiled, uncurling to face her. Adora's face was flushed, the impacts from Catra's lipstick plastered across her face like a crime scene. Even Hordak would have struggled to beat a case with this much evidence. Slipping off her lap was hindered by Adora's fingers trailing along her body in desperate hope - Catra very nearly returned to her comfortable perch and her pleasurable pursuits. "I'm going to move to the bedroom," She purred, looming over Adora. "You're welcome to come with me." To snuggle, obviously. Nothing more.

Unless Adora changed her mind.

Adora watched her walk away, back straight, hips tauntingly dragging at her attention. There was a moment as the door closed that she saw a golden eye staring back at her. It disappeared an instant before the door shut. A blink. No, Catra didn't blink. (Of course she did, everyone did, but she didn't *blink* blink.)

That fucking snake-tongued, deceptive, trickster, slippery arse (stop thinking about her arse, *stop thinking about her arse*), had fucking *winked* at her. Going into Adora's own room, she had *winked* at her. After…

Adora forced her fingers to unclench from the fabric of the sofa before she tore it. Catra was dangerous. Adora was very much in danger.

Walking over to the counter, she retrieved her gun, sliding the magazine back into place and racking the chamber. Having a gun in her hand usually let her feel better, more in control. It only made her feel worse this time.

She instantly removed the clip and ejected the unspent bullet.

Falling onto the couch, she ignored the heat still burning into the cushions. Burning through her.

Putting the weapon on the coffee table, she dragged a woolen blanket from underneath and wrapped it around her shoulders. It smelt musty from lack of use, but detracted from the scent of Catra's musk as she forced a cushion under her head.

Adora blinked as a treacherous thought slithered in through the damning pleasure that still filled her body - had Catra done all *that* merely to trick Adora into swapping bed for couch?

She glared at the door until her eyelids drooped closed.

Chapter 3: The Escape

Heat and fresh food. Cooking. Close, inside the apartment. Intruder!

Adora snapped into action from a dead start, loading, cocking, and aiming her gun before it had even finished lining up a trajectory.

Catra glanced at the gun with the same level of concern she might have a pointed finger. "Morning," She grinned, continuing to stir the pan on the stove. "How do you like your eggs?"

"*Catra?!*" Adora hissed, forcing her thumb to slide the safety back on and her finger not to tighten. "What are you doing?"

"Depends?" Catra side-eyed the weapon as she buttered toast on the sideboard. "Do I need a lawyer present?"

Adora begrudgingly removed the clip once more, slowly ejecting the bullet and placing in beside the trigger. "What the hell sort of game are you playing?" She snapped, straightening her dishevelled outfit as she stumbled upright.

"Breakfast," Catra frowned disapprovingly. "Honestly, is there anything in your fridge that *hasn't* expired? I think I've seen more life there than I have in some jury pools."

"I haven't had a chance to go shopping." Adora lied as she stared at the intruder.

"Uh-huh," Catra eyed her right back. "You know you've got a tell, right?"

The detective reared back. "I do not!"

"Agree to disagree," Catra split the eggs between two plates and slid the toast slices alongside. "But I'd not play poker if I were you, a good shark would steal the clothes off your back."

That's when Adora noticed what her 'guest' was wearing. "Hey, that's my shirt!"

"Well, *my* clothes smelled like a winery had thrown up on them," Catra pointed out. "I may be jobless, but I still have standards." She fell silent, pouring water into the egg pan to soak. It was clear that the recent betrayal still stung. "Here," She turned with a smile, carrying the plates over to the couch. "I'm guessing you eat your meals over here." She slid onto half the couch like she owned the place, plate in hand, fork already delivering clusters of egg.

"It's nice to relax at the end of the day." Adora muttered, picking up her food as she stared sullenly at the intruder. She knew Catra had a slim build but the shirt Adora kept for formal occasions hung loose on her like a sail in a slack wind. Stars above, she could see the sharp contours of her collarbones, the flat, *uninterrupted* plane of her sternum. One twitch, one shift in the wrong direction, one breath of wind,

"Are you okay?" The shirt twisted with Catra, taunting her with the idea of revelation. "You look a bit peaky."

"Fine," Adora strangled out, tearing her eyes away as she hurried to the counter.

"If you say so." Catra shrugged uncaringly.

Adora didn't have a defence for that, but her stomach was rumbling loud enough to risk the possibly poisoned food being offered to her. "Fuck me." Adora mumbled around her first mouthful.

"Yeah," Catra slid one leg onto the coffee table, wrapping the other over it. "It would have been better if I had fresh ingredients, but it's edible."

"*Edible?*" Adora moaned. "If I could cook this well, I'd never eat the canteen breakfast again!" Lynn would be heartbroken, but Adora would get over it by the next breakfast.

"You should see what I can do with a good piece of salmon." Catra grinned.

"Oh no," Adora threatened with the tines of her fork. "You got your one night of pity. Soon as breakfast is over, you're signing that piece of paper and getting out of my hair for good."

"That's a shame," Catra kept a carefully neutral expression. "You have such pretty hair, when it's not tacked up in that dumb ponytail." She chewed her food, eyes roving around the apartment as Adora flushed and returned to her feast. It was gone within minutes.

"Okay!" Adora announced, throwing her plate in the sink and marching over to snatch Catra's. "Breakfast is done, you've got clothes," (That looked disgustingly good on her, but Adora kept *that* thought to herself.) "Time for you to head back to your place and make your own plans." She dumped the extra plate in the sink and began washing up. Catra had made no move by the time she glared back. "Well?" Adora demanded.

"I rent my apartment from the firm," She admitted. "Halls and corridors are technically private property of a divested holding company. They can revoke access based upon anyone that they deem potentially threatening - and that includes someone caught during a drugs bust. All my documents and everything else I have is in that apartment, and they're not going to let me near it."

Adora scowled, fingers tightening against the sponge. She couldn't throttle Catra (even if her mind was tempting her with images of tracing fingers along that slender neck) but she could vent her frustrations on the cleaning equipment. "Fine," She snapped, slamming the plate onto the drying rack. "I'll help you get your stuff, you get out of my hair for good."

"Promise." Catra smiled emptily, twisted fingers held up in the air.

Adora scoffed, grabbing her jacket. The sooner this was over with, the better.

"Detective Grayskull," Adora flashed her ID to the receptionist behind the secure counter. "I'm here to escort Miss D'riluth to collect her belongings."

"Of course," The receptionist said calmly. "May I see a copy of the judge's order?"

"Told you." Catra murmured as Adora put her badge away.

"Miss D'riluth has an apartment in the building." She said slowly. "Her personal belongings are in that apartment."

"That may be," Adora reminded herself that she wasn't allowed to shoot anyone, the smirking lawyer behind her or the smug receptionist ahead. "But the apartments are privately owned, independent of the building. The building, Detective, is owned by Prime. If you wish to enter any further, you will require a judge's order."

Adora said nothing as she pulled her phone out and began dialling. "Judge Núñez?" Adora spoke calmly into the handset as she kept her eyes locked on the receptionist. "Detective Grayskull. I have a citizen here who's been evicted from a company apartment and denied access to return and collect their belongings. Can I call in my favour to have a van and a couple of movers here to assist?"

"Nice try," The receptionist scoffed derisively. "But I'm not falling for," Adora turned her screen to display the name on the call.

Judge Núñez. And the speaker was dimly sounding, saying that a van was already being diverted to meet them. "Be advised that I have a receptionist refusing entry. Nametag identifies him as 'Boyd', I'll ask him for a last name," Adora tilted the microphone away from her mouth. "You're Boyd…?" She left the empty gap hanging in the air.

"Now, see here," Boyd raised a stern figure.

"Boyd?" Catra raised an eyebrow. "Don't." Boyd knew Catra's reputation from before her fall, and lowered his finger.

"*Perhaps*," He suggested intently. "It would not be inappropriate if Miss D'riluth were to be escorted?" Adora kept listening to the phone, raising one finger as she did so. "I could unlock the elevator to allow you easy access to and from the floor of her apartment?" Boyd sounded increasingly unnerved.

"Judge?" Adora asked peacefully. "I've got permission to enter the apartment, your people should be allowed up when they arrive. We'll start preparing everything for their arrival." She ended the call, still staring down the staunch defender.

"The elevators are to your left." Boyd stammered, gesturing to one side.

Adora silently led the way, ushering Catra in before her.

"You called a *judge* to get me into my apartment?" Catra glared as the doors closed.

"I called a *mover*," Every smile she showed Catra was a little different from before. This one was smug like she'd won a case, but tinged with the same duplicity from the night she'd followed Catra. "Last name Núñez, first name Judge."

"You know that's not how he took it." Catra scoffed.

"At what point did I misrepresent my actions?" Adora said evenly. "I called some movers and requested a van. If he chose to interpret that as me contacting a judicial official, who am I to judge?"

Catra glanced at her with sly respect. "Don't worry," Adora had noticed the look. "If it gets bad, I know a lawyer who owes me a favour."

"I owe you a fresh shirt and a night in a cramped room." Catra retorted.

"There you go again," Adora tutted as the doors opened. "It's like you're deliberately misunderstanding me."

Catra strode down the corridor like she still belonged there, Adora following the easy flutter of her shirt. (Wait, did she mean her shirt or *her* shirt?) "This is us." Adora mentally consigned the fate of the shirt to the whims of fate as Catra unlocked a door that wouldn't look out of place in a boardroom.

Inside was *gorgeous*. The living room alone was larger than Adora's entire apartment. There was even a fucking *chandelier*, if she didn't want to use the *fireplace*. Floor-to-ceiling windows that gave such a clear view of the landscape that Adora couldn't convince herself she wasn't seeing the sea on the horizon. A thick leather couch deeper than her bed back home occupied less than a quarter of the space, and Adora couldn't imagine the struggle of trying to clean the carpets deep enough to sink her whole foot into.

"It's not much," Catra said nonchalantly. "But it's when I hang my suits."

Adora took a deep breath through her nose. "Where's the kitchen?"

She regretted asking. It looked like something from a professional restaurant, neatly compressed to a usable scale. "Drink?" Catra offered, gesturing to a double-door wine fridge stacked with bottles. Adora marched over to the cupboard under the kitchen sink and withdrew a thick roll of bin bags. "Here," She tossed them over to Catra. "Fold and shove. It's not pretty, but it gets people packed faster."

"Tip from your moving friend?" Catra raised an eyebrow as she tore a bag free and shook it loose.

"Domestic violence cases," Adora explained flatly. "Clothes go in the bags, anything breakable goes in a case. If you can replace it, you can leave it behind. If it's precious enough to miss, you bring

it. If you even *think* you'll miss it later, it comes along. Where's the bedroom?"

"Across the living room," Catra eyed the marks on Adora's neck. She'd covered them up well, but there was a subtle shading that gave it away. "First door on the left. The sheets should be clean," She smiled politely. "I tip the cleaning service *very* well." That shading on Adora's neck was more noticeable as the blood pooled beneath.

She stomped across the apartment, muttering angrily beneath her breath as Catra followed politely behind. "Well?" She demanded as they entered the room. Of course, it was big enough to house a mini-golf course around the super-king-sized bed. "Where's the closet?"

"Closet?" Catra purred, perching on the end of the mattress and patting the duvet gently. "I've spent plenty of time in there, maybe too much. I prefer it in here - better views." She blatantly examined the fuming detective with a hungry gaze.

"*Where?*" Adora snapped, refusing to be drawn into the games.

"Across the hall." Catra shrugged.

"You keep your clothes in the hall closet?" Adora rolled her eyes.

"No," Catra called comfortably as Adora strode to the doors. "I keep my clothes closet in the hall." The stunned silence was exactly what she had been expecting as she sauntered up behind the dumbfounded blonde. "Like what you see?" She propped her chin on Adora's shoulder, staring into the walk-in closet that could (and did) house an entire shoe avenue.

"You know what I see?" Adora growled. "Exactly what you said I would - no pictures, no traces of anyone who cares about you." Her words cut harsher than she expected, and the comfortable warmth left her shoulder. "Catra, I didn't mean,"

"Yes, you did," She brushed past, trailing a hand along the shelves. "It's all glitz and glamour to make the truth more comfortable - I have literally everything I can want, and it's empty." She stopped by a sharp red outfit. "This is my favourite suit," Her back was to Adora, but the tension in her muscles was clear. "Do you know why?"

"No," Adora admitted, guilted into answering. "But I remember it. You were representing Colbat for battery. We got him for assault because enough people heard the shouting, you managed to get that down to time served because you dragged the case out."

"You paid attention to *me*, in a thousand tiny glances," Catra swallowed. "Maybe it's because you hated my guts, but it was the only real interest anyone showed me in a long time."

Adora placed her hand over Catra's, feeling the fabric winding through her fingers. "We don't have time for this," She warned. "Stop playing games."

"*One kiss?*" Catra whined, stretching back towards Adora's face with a sarcastic smirk.

"Not a chance," Adora swore, shoving her away. "Grab a bag and start cramming." Catra laughed and snatched a bag.

Adora was surgical about the whole affair. Six identical mugs that Catra loved? Two were stuffed with socks, wrapped in a shirt, and crammed in a case. Expensive perfume that had to be imported? Too risky, it could shatter and ruin any number of items.

Within the hour, she had carved through the apartment, slicing it away from Catra like a tumour.

"That's it," Catra slumped onto the naked bed. The silk sheets had wrapped her crockery, and her voluminous duvet was crammed in a bin bag. The bed itself would have to be left behind. "That's… *it.*" She sounded disappointed by the completion of the hurried task.

"What did you expect, a fanfare of trumpets?" Adora snapped. Her patience had disappeared by the third round of shoe sorting, and her shirt was clinging to the sweat gathered from doing all the heavy lifting.

"I expected to feel more," She cast around the empty room for a suitable adjective. "*More*."

Adora let out a low sigh and joined her on the bed. "Yeah," Adora placed a gentle hand on Catra's shoulder, and squeezed comfortingly. "Change is always hard but you've not had time to process this." Catra reached idly for Adora's collar, only for her to grab the wandering hand. "*Enough.*" She snapped.

"Adora," Catra breathed. "*Please*, just for a minute." Adora sighed, releasing her grip. Catra moved slowly, reaching across to grasp the far lapel as she turned, nuzzling into her shoulder as she pulled Adora tight. "Thank you." The words were whispered so softly that the detective nearly didn't hear them. She sat for a long minute, taking increasingly shuddering breaths. Adora restrained a rumbling growl in her chest, rolling her eyes to the ceiling. If she ever found herself in the same room as Catra's old bosses, she was going to draw her weapon for what she was being forced to do.

Wrapping an arm around Catra's shoulder, she pulled her in with a reluctant grip. "One minute." She muttered. "*One.*"

"Maybe two?" Catra whispered against her collar.

Drawing *and* aiming. "Maybe two." Adora conceded.

After maybe more than two minutes, a buzz sounded in her pocket, and they broke apart. "It's the movers," She announced. "They're pulling up now."

The sound of an opening door had Catra instantly on her feet. "Stay here." She warned, striding out into the hallway that lead the the living room. Adora ignored the command, following her

out until she could peer around the corner and watch events unfold.

Shadow Weaver was standing in the doorway, a spectre of death and misery. "Catra," She sneered. "How did you get in?" She stalked forward, forcing her protege back by presence alone as the door swung shut again.

"I spoke nicely to the receptionist," Catra spoke calmly, but Adora could see the tension in her balling fists. "He was kind enough to allow me through to my apartment."

"Is that so?" The senior lawyer hissed. "Under escort, I understand."

"Under escort." Adora affirmed, rounding into view.

"And under false pretences." If she was surprised to see the blonde coming around the corner, it didn't show.

"At what point did I misrepresent my actions?" Adora smoothly interjected. "Judge Núñez is a good friend of mine, who owes me a favour for helping him sort out some parking tickets. It turned out that he'd been given the wrong form, and I was able to help him avoid a hefty fine. He runs a moving firm, very big on paying back what's owed. Which part of that would be considered illegal?"

"You intimated that you had called a police van and police backup to forcibly enter a property." Shadow Weaver snapped.

"I *asked* for a *van* and a couple of *movers*," She gestured to the knocking door behind Shadow Weaver. "Those are the movers, their van is outside."

"Don't worry," Catra glared. "I'll take my stuff and get out of here." She moved to the door, and Shadow Weaver moved to block her path. "Of course, if you don't want to let us leave, I'm sure there's an officer who would be willing to arrest you on attempted kidnapping and illegal imprisonment charges," Catra

threatened icily. "Or maybe it's just robbery, for when you try keeping my stuff from leaving with me."

"Keep it civil now." Adora warned, crossing her arms in a way that revealed the glint of her badge and the stocky outline of her gun.

"Detective Grayskull," Shadow Weaver smiled, the scarred corners of her mouth twitching like dying limbs. "I read the report on your actions last night - impressive work. Perhaps you might consider some contract work with our firm."

"Quite frankly, I'd sooner have my arse kicked around court by Catra every day for the rest of my career than ever work for you," Adora scoffed. "*Ma'am.*"

"Ouch," Catra smirked. "That's gotta be the fastest you've ever been rejected - and with a face like that,"

A thunderclap filled the room as Shadow Weaver drew her arm back for a second strike. "How *dare* you!?" Catra reeled back, clutching her face in shock and horror.

A pin could have dropped in the silence. A button unlatching was even louder.

Adora's gun was unlatched. And Catra hadn't even seen her hand get anywhere close.

"Oops," Adora growled. "I think the catch is faulty. I should probably see to that." Coldly withdrawing her gun, she kept it pointed at the floor as her spare hand addressed the holster. It was difficult, since she didn't break eye contact with the pinnacle of callousness.

"Reactions dull with age, you know," Catra said quietly, moving back to an umbrella stand. "Probably explains why your last case was so sloppy."

Shadow Weaver turned on her with a snarl, and Catra drew a bat, ready to fight or throw as required. A deafening click broke the

silence. Adora still had one hand tucked around the holster but her gun was now angled from the hip.

"I think that's got it sorted," She observed, latching and unlatching the button. "I'll put my sidearm away now, since there doesn't appear to be a use for it."

"Good call, Detective," Catra growled low in her throat. "I suppose you'll keep it ready in case you happen across a criminal."

"I think we'll all be leaving," Adora warned. "Miss Weaver, you go first - I'll make sure that the vacating tenant doesn't damage the property." Holstering her gun revealed the dull gleam of her handcuffs.

For all her legal bluster, Shadow Weaver was an old woman, outnumbered and outmatched. Could she overturn the arrest? Absolutely. Would word spread about how she has been humiliated, unable to even evict a disgraced ex-employee who had been a constant thorn in her side?

"Here," Pulling something from her pocket, Catra tossed it at Shadow Weaver's feet. "Might as well get what you came for." Sneering, the bitter crone picked up the paperwork and unfolded it. Adora recognised the non-compete clause Catra had shown her the night before. "I'll expect my money within the week," Catra said coldly. "Or I'll take you for every penny that you're worth."

"It'll be there," Shadow Weaver glared. "Anything to finally be rid of you." She turned and walked through the door, leaving a confused trio of overalls waiting in the opening.

"Kyle, Rogelio," Adora marched over threw them each a hefty bag of Catra's belongings. "We'll have to catch up later, we're on a clock here."

"Hi Adora, long time," A brown woman with shaved sides around a set of dreadlocks sarcastically remarked as she barged past. "Nah, you're not interrupting us, we're happy to get dragged off

an easy job to come and help your pro-bono, bleeding heart, efforts."

"Pro-bono?" Catra raised an eyebrow. "You're not even paying them?"

"Nah, not *Detective Grayskull*," The burly mover returned with the two heaviest boxes stacked atop each other and no sign of stress. "She knows that Judge will see us right."

"Unbelievable," Catra shook her head mockingly. "And you say *I'm* the bad guy?" She stared at Adora.

The mover smirked, noticing the tension. "Lonnie," Hefting the weight onto her hip, she held out a hand.

"Catra," She shook, appreciating the firm grip. "I'll make sure you get your money's worth."

"That'll be the day."

As quick as Adora had been at extracting Catra from her apartment, the three movers were faster to remove her belongings from the building. Adora helped some, carrying down boxes and bags as required, while Catra spared a few minutes to talk with Lonnie in the apartment. The van had already peeled away by the time she and Catra were once more sat in her patrol car. "Can we go back to your place?" Catra asked absently. "I think I forgot something."

"Sure," Adora slowly pulled away from the pristine environment. The longer she was near the gleaming white structure, the more it turned her stomach. She was fine letting Catra back into her apartment if it meant getting away from the haunting building.

"What the fuck is this?" Adora swore. How the three movers had managed to place boxes behind her front door after leaving was inconsequential compared to the issue of forcing her way inside.

"Hey, make room." Catra pressed up behind her as she tried to squeeze in as well.

Adora was through the gap like a shot before she even realised.

Inside was packed literally floor to ceiling with boxes. Adora could faintly see a break in the distance, praying that it indicated her couch had been spared the trauma. "Let's see," Catra was already rummaging through one of the boxes. "Aha, I didn't forget it!" Emerging from within the container was an expensive coffee maker and the two mugs she had salvaged from the wreckage of her old life. "I was really worried for a moment there."

Adora watched her slip through the chaos as naturally as breathing as she set the machine up on the counter. Scoffing in disgust, she forced her way through the onslaught towards the oasis of serenity beneath the window. "How did they even get this in here?!" She yelled, forced to hop and leap over a solid wall of containers to reach the couch.

"I let them take the rest of my wine cooler," Catra raised her voice over the boiling water. "You wouldn't believe how expensive some of those bottles were. I kept a few of my favourites, but the rest went with them." Filling the mugs with coffee that most people would never know existed, she gracefully slinked through the wreckage of her life to perch happily in her seat from the night before.

"Did you put anything in this?" Adora glared as she took the cup.

"I'd have sprinkled some cinnamon, but you're out." Catra grinned.

Adora glared, refusing to be drawn into another conversation about her lack of diet and shopping.

"I'm going to press charges against those three for breaking and entering." The detective fumed over the alluring scent of her coffee.

"I thought you left the door unlocked?" Catra blew innocently across the surface of her mug.

"You know I didn't," Adora glared, refusing to let the delicate taste soothe her rage. "What, did Prime make a copy of my keys as well?"

"No," Catra kept her gaze directed across the ocean of cardboard. "But you keep a spare key by the door. Very careless," She smirked. "Anyone with a skinny arm could reach in and grab it."

"Seriously, Kyle?" Adora groaned as she let her head fall back against the threadbare cushions. Even from there, she couldn't escape sight of the towering boxes. "You can't stay here," Adora warned. "Even if I didn't think you were gaming me, there's literally not room for you." Half of what Catra said were outright lies, and the other half was manipulative to an extreme. Either way, Adora didn't trust her.

"I know," Catra said quietly. "But I needed to get out of there before Hordak had all of the Prime firm on me. This was the only place I thought might be safe."

It was manipulation, that quiet tone of reserved fear, the faint hints of hope in her voice. "One week," Adora glared. "And then you can put your stuff in a storage locker and get out of my life."

"One week," Catra agreed, settling into place beside her. "It's a date."

Adora put serious thought towards pulling her weapon again.

Chapter 4: The Trial

Either a bomb was about to detonate or her alarm was going off. "Five more minutes," Adora mumbled sleepily into her pillow, knowing that it would pay her complaints no heed. If anything, it grew even louder. "I'm armed." She warned, fumbling for a pillow from the other side of the bed to attack with. One came to hand, and she skipped a second warning, choosing instead to simply smack the alarm to the floor and smoother the bleeping device with the padding. Mission accomplished, she rolled back over and pulled the duvet over her shoulder.

That's when her phone went off. It was a powerful vibration that she could sense through the bed from the bedside table. Clawing around behind her, she grabbed the screen and pressed it to her face. "Detective Grayskull." She made an effort to sound awake, and not like she was in bed.

"You're not out of bed yet, are you?" Glimmer harshly deduced her current status without even trying.

"Sure I am," Adora lied smoothly. "I'm looking over the Lashor file right now."

"Nice try," Glimmer responded sarcastically. "But you text me last night to call you at this time because you'd probably smother your alarm instead of getting up."

Adora rolled over and glared at the pillow on the floor with a suspicious eye. 'Traitor' she thought. "I was on stakeout last night," She yawned. "Technically, I was on stakeout this morning." Leaning down, she swatted away the pillow and stabbed at the alarm clock until it stopped beeping. Five hours of sleep. Not the worst she'd done before. Certainly a crying distance from her best.

"Yeah, well, you've got court this afternoon," Glimmer reminded her. "And I've got a message for you; if you don't get that pretty

arse of yours through the shower and out of the door soon, you'll be late to court and everyone is going to have something to say about it."

"You think my arse is pretty?" Adora grinned sleepily, falling back against her pillows.

"I'm just the messenger," Glimmer reminded her. "The *other* message is; if you're arse isn't at court before the hearing starts, it's on the bench for the rest of the year."

"What is it with everyone and my arse this morning?" Adora grumbled, reluctantly kicking back the covers.

"Well, it is such a *pretty* arse." Glimmer sarcastically reminded her.

"Careful," Adora warned, wandering over to her wardrobe with a yawn. "Wouldn't want Bow hearing that."

"Why?" Glimmer teased. "You've only got a pretty arse, he has a gorgeous behind."

"Damn it!" Adora swore. *Where* had her good shirt gone?

"What?" Glimmer was instantly in panic mode.

"My dress shirt," Adora cursed. "It's missing."

"Don't panic!" Glimmer instructed. "Go to the far left, go about a foot in, and look there." Shifting to the far side of the wardrobe, Adora flicked through the clothing until she found what she was looking for.

"This will never work," She grumbled. "It's not got a collar on it."

"And?" Glimmer demanded. "I know it's now your fashion, but if it *fits*,"

"Glimmer," Adora repeated. "I *need* a collar."

Tense silence echoed down the line.

"*Why* would you need a collar?" Glimmer groaned. "Tell me that it's because you got injured on the stakeout last night."

"I *did* get injured on the stakeout last night." Adora insisted.

"You stubbed your toe on the door," Glimmer pinced the bridge of her nose. "Fuck, I *knew* I shouldn't have swapped off this case. Okay. Okay, okay, okay. Go to the spare chest of drawers, one down, right-hand side." Adora followed the instructions, instantly identifying Glimmer's train of thought.

"Come *on*," She dangled the offensive piece of clothing in her hand like it was evidence in a murder case. "You *can't* be serious!"

"I'm sorry," The prosecutor didn't sound the least bit apologetic. "Was it not good enough for you? Would you prefer to simply rock up in your dress uniform and try explaining why you're not dressed appropriately for court?"

"It's better than a bloody silk scarf!" It was eggshell white, soft as a dream, and totally inappropriate. Even if Adora knew better than to put a solid line around her neck, it would never suit her.

"Fine," Glimmer snapped. "You've got until you get out of the shower to think up a better solution. Meanwhile, I'll be think through everything in that room and, yep, that's basically your only option." Adora growled at the stern tone.

"Have I ever mentioned how irritating it is that a prosecutor knows all the clothes in my house better than I do?"

"Have you ever *heard* of anyone else *needing* a prosecutor to sort their clothing arrangements?"

"I'm not saying anything without my lawyer." Adora retorted, hating Glimmer's laugh as tossed the phone back onto the bed.

"Adora?" Captain Angella was waiting outside the courtroom when Adora arrived, cursing her poor luck. "What *are* you wearing?"

She'd never seen Adora in a dress scarf before.

"Sorry Captain," Adora apologised. "Couldn't find my regular shirt."

"But, why do you need a scarf?" She watched the blush creep up Adora's neck, somehow not affecting certain patches of skin. The detective had become adept at hiding bruises. "Here," Stepping up, she began adjusting the necktie to look more presentable. "Remember," The captain warned. "You're not trying to convince *her*. You know he's guilty, *she* knows he's guilty."

"'I'm showing the jury how he's guilty'," Adora recited by rote. "'They know what's right, all we have to do is show them the evidence and they'll do the rest.'"

"Wow," Angella grinned. "Am I really *that* predictable?"

"Only because you've told it to me every case Catra's been involved in for the past year." Adora smiled, adjusting her collar again.

"Hmm," Those indomitable eyes twinkled at her. It was unnerving that Angella, feared by the criminal element and loved by the mistreated masses she helped get a second chance, could still look at her best detective and assume that everything was going to be alright. "Are you,"

"I'm fine." Adora snapped, instantly regretting it. That twinkle was practically a shining gleam. "Fuck it," She sighed, forcing her shoulders down. "Might as well get this over with."

"Eyes straight," Angella reminded her. "Directly to the desk. Don't look at *her*, don't talk to *her*, don't even think about *her*."

"Catra." Adora let the word slip before she could catch it.

"Sure," Angella clapped her on the shoulder, watching how Adora barely noticed the impact. Her mind was already "Catra." She

muttered despairing thoughts as Adora slipped through the courtroom doors.

Straight ahead. Down the narrow aisle. To the table. Look at the open file. Don't make eye contact.

"Hey Adora," A smugly warm breath ghosted past her ear.

"Catra." She growled, ignoring the familiarity.

"I've been looking over your case," She walked around the front of the table, leaning over until her shirt parted the barest fraction from her neck. "I don't like your chances of winning. Of course, I could be persuaded to apply my services to your cause."

"How about you just do the right thing for once?" Adora snarled the last of her clean air before she had to smell Catra's perfume. It was subtle, tugging the senses to focus more on her.

"Awww, but that's no fun," She purred, sliding a finger onto the paper to make it seem like she was discussing the words on the page. "Why can't I just do things my way, and you can pay me back?"

"No." She growled, clenching both fists until they hurt. It didn't stop her focus from slipping further. "Remember how well that worked out last time."

"Hmm," Catra acknowledged. "Then maybe I should just stick to your side, learn from the best how to be a sap."

"All rise for the honourable Judge Micah." Catra returned to her rightful place as the assembled rose politely.

"Be seated." Micah waved from his bench.

"The defence moves for a mistrial," Adora glared as the expensive suit rudely approached the desk without waiting for leave. "I have a signed document stating that Catra D'riluth has agreed not to continue practicing law."

"This has got to be the fourth time that she's tried this," Adora growled to her partner against crime. "Why does she even bother?"

"Shhh," Catra hushed. "I like this next part the most." She knew why the old crone was doing this - if one of them agreed, she would no longer be allowed to fight Prime's interests.

"This says that she agrees not to partake in any action that could potentially cause a negative effect on the business of your firm, Miss Weaver," Judge Micah glanced dismissively at the fuming lawyer. "I'd say that anyone worth having a non-compete clause involved in their exit paperwork is probably someone who could prolong this case and give you more billable hours, wouldn't you agree?"

"Surely this constitutes a conflict of interests," Shadow Weaver snarled. "Both she and you were formerly under my tutelage, this is obviously an unfair bias against my case."

"You had the option of filing a mistrial when you learned that I was going to be presiding," Judge Micah glared. "Either I can hold you in contempt for delaying this long, or I can report your ineptitude in my findings."

"Do me a favour?" Catra smiled tauntingly as Shadow Weaver threw them a filthy glance on her way back to her desk. "If I lunge for the bitch, you block the bailiffs long enough for me to get a few good punches in."

"Not a chance," Adora warned. "I'm closer, I get the punches."

A single moment of contact as Catra crossed her legs and let her foot brush against Adora's calf.

"I'm thinking dinner when we win," She mused. "How about that bar I heard Sparkles mention?"

"Frosta's?" She shuddered. There was something unnerving about the short young woman with the angry eyes. Maybe it was her

rumoured ties to organised crime. "What about the vegetarian place Scorpia found?" Catra's defection from Prime had convinced a few of their kinder members to follow suit. Sergeant Scorpia was fitting in very nicely with her new team, even if she was most dealing with paperwork and community outreach.

"The one that she hates but keeps going back to because she's hopelessly in love with the owner?" Catra reminded her.

"At least Perfuma feels the same way," Adora protested. "They just don't know how to express it yet."

"Gee, I wonder what that's like," Catra gave a throaty chuckle that made Adora's stomach clench and the hickies along her neck ache. She silently cursed Catra for stealing her good shirt to flaunt in the courtroom, same as how she had stolen her phone to message Glimmer to ensure Adora woke up that morning. "How about that new place with the hot owner and the annoying chef?"

"Salenias," Adora nodded. Mermista was heavy on the soul, and blamed it all on the chef they could all hear singing from the kitchen. "I thought you hated that place."

"Yeah, well," It was true, what you ordered was not necessarily what you got - Sea Hawk was as likely to spruce up a recipe as he was to throw it away altogether. "Maybe we'll get lucky and see him run around with his arms on fire again."

Judge Micah rapped his gavel, calling for silence. With one final supportive squeeze, the pair readied themselves for their next battle against Hordak, Weaver, and their twisted empire.

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